Persian poet Firdausi, author of the 'Shahnamah', who later fell

out with Mahmud. Alberuni, a scholar and traveller, was a

contemporary, and in his books he gives us a glimpse into other

aspects of life in central Asia then. Born near Khiva, but of Persian

descent, he came to India and travelled a great deal. He tells us

df the great irrigation works in the Chola kingdom in the south,

** There is a curious passage relating to this defeat in an old chronicle in Persian, the Tarikh*

-i- Sorath (translated by Ranchodji Amarji, Bombay, 1882) p. 112: 'Shah Mahmud took

to his heels in dismay and saved his life, but many of hisfollowers of both sexes were captured..

Turk, Afghan, and Mughal female prisoners, if they happened to be virgins, were accepted

as wives by the. Indian soldiers. . . .The bowels of the others, however, were cleaned by

means of emetics and purgatives, and thereafter the captives were married to men of similar rank.' 'Low females were joined to low men. Respectable mm were compelled to shave off

their beards, and were enrolled among the Shekhavat and the Wadhel tribes of Rajputs;

whilst the lower kinds were allotted to the castes of Kolis, Khantas, Babrias, and Mers.'

I am not myself acquainted with the Tarikh-i-Sorath and do not know how far it can